

More Permissive, More Populist?

Electoral Permissiveness and the Translation of Anti-Elite Attitudes into Votes

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Independent Research Project

August 2026

Abstract

Why do populist parties receive more votes under more permissive electoral rules? This paper explores the individual-level mechanism underlying the relationship between electoral permissiveness and the vote shares of populist parties. An influential explanation is that restrictive rules incite anti-elite voters to abandon less viable populist parties in favour of more competitive options. Therefore, the association between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting should be stronger in more permissive electoral environments. We test this prediction using two complementary designs. First, we employ a cross-national design covering 42 election studies across 33 countries. Second, we employ a within-respondent design for the case of Swiss voters who simultaneously cast a vote for both the proportional National Council and the majoritarian Council of States. A strong association between anti-elite sentiments and populist voting exists in both designs. However, neither offers compelling evidence that permissive electoral rules enhance this connection. The cross-national evidence argues against substantial positive moderation and the Swiss comparison is inconclusive. These findings point towards electoral-supply and other contextual mechanisms as important explanations of cross-system differences in populist success.

1. Introduction

Populist parties generally gain more votes when legislatures are elected by way of proportional representation than when they are elected by a majority of votes in single-member districts (Becher et al. 2023; Self & Hicken, 2018). The usual explanation is strategic coordination. In single-member districts with a plurality of votes, voters are likely to vote for the most likely winner; thus, supporters of smaller parties are likely to abandon their preferred party in order to support one with a greater chance of winning (Duverger, 1954; Cox, 1997). In such districts, populist parties, which are often smaller and less established than their main competitors, are more likely to receive few votes.

If there is any truth to the voter-side coordination argument, then the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting will be stronger in districts of larger size than in smaller districts. In other words, not only will populist parties perform better in districts of larger size than in smaller districts, but also the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting will become steeper as districts get bigger. This paper's goal is to test that mechanism.

It is important to distinguish between the individual and aggregate levels of analysis. Parties are aware of the rules of the competition for votes prior to the actual voting by citizens. Therefore, not only can the aggregate level of support for populist parties vary as a function of

differences in rules, but also the supply and strategic positioning of parties (Meguid, 2005; Van der Brug et al., 2005). Thus, the same level of anti-elite resentment can be translated into different levels of populist voting by voters in different countries, depending on the degree of permissiveness of the competition for votes. What the voter-side coordination argument predicts is a change in the individual association between citizens' anti-elite attitudes and populist voting in more permissive systems of voting, not a change in the aggregate level of populist support. While a change in the parties on offer is a possible alternative explanation of the aggregate pattern (Meguid, 2005; Van der Brug et al., 2005), this hypothesis is not tested.

This paper uses two complementary designs. The first is a cross-national design using a multilevel logit model applied to 42 election studies in 33 countries from CSES Module 5 (53,230 respondents) (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). It interacts an individual anti-elite attitude scale with the log median district magnitude, i.e. the median number of seats available in a country's districts, in each study. It is expected that in countries with more permissive district magnitudes, the attitude slope would increase. The second is a within-respondent comparison that examines Swiss voters who, in October 2019, completed both a proportional National Council ballot and a majoritarian Council of States ballot at the same sitting. It is here expected that the association between anti-elite attitudes and voting for the Swiss People's Party (SVP) is stronger on the National Council ballot than on the Council of States ballot.

Neither design produces the results required by the hypothesis. In the cross-national analysis, the interaction term is -0.052 (0.053), which is not significantly different from zero and opposite in sign to the prediction. This result does not change when using district magnitude for the individual respondent, or when using a different threshold for populist parties. In the Swiss comparison, the interaction term is 0.182 (0.154) and decreases to 0.084 in a conditional logit model. That estimate is based on only 209 discordant respondents whose choice for the Swiss People's Party (SVP) differs across ballots, which limits the design's ability to rule out substantive size effects. The cross-national result should thus be understood as evidence against a large positive moderation, but not against every smaller effect, and the Swiss result as inconclusive. What both studies share is the strong association between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting. Thus, the findings of this paper do not support the view that strategic defection by anti-elite voters is the main driver of populist parties' greater success under more permissive rules.

The association between electoral permissiveness and aggregate populist success is already well established (Becher et al., 2023; Self & Hicken, 2018), yet a direct test of whether electoral rules change how anti-elite attitudes translate into votes has been less clear. These two analyses address that question with different sources of leverage and different weaknesses. Section 2 develops the argument and hypotheses, Section 3 describes the data and models, Section 4 reports the results, and Section 5 discusses what those results allow us to conclude and the study's limitations.

2. Theory and Hypotheses

2.1 The attitude scale

The ideational approach defines populism in terms of a morally pure people set against a corrupt elite, an opposition in which citizens as well as parties can believe (Mudde, 2004). The definition was then translated into survey measures, such as the scale from Akkerman et al. (2014) and related batteries such as the three-dimensional scale proposed by Schulz et al. (2018). Many surveys of populist attitudes, however, have a difficult factor structure that does not travel well across countries. Item-response tests of these batteries in several European countries have given concrete evidence of this problem (Castanho Silva et al., 2020; Van Hauwaert et al., 2020). Another issue is that populist attitudes might form a syndrome whose components are not interchangeable. Thus, when averaging items, a high score on one component can easily compensate for a low score on another (Wuttke et al., 2020).

The measure of populist attitudes used in this study is based on five items of the CSES Module 5 anti-elite battery. It captures a strong anti-elite sentiment but does not measure people-centrism or the Manichaeic worldview that the full ideational definition also includes (Mudde, 2004). Hence, all claims made in this study about populist attitudes refer to the anti-elite part of these attitudes. The restriction limits how the null results can be interpreted (see Section 5). However, it is in line with the question that this study tries to answer, i.e. the question of how the strategic defection of anti-elite voters to populist parties is affected by the electoral rules that apply to legislative elections.

2.2 Electoral permissiveness and conversion of attitudes into votes

Duverger (1954) introduced two mechanisms for the plurality rule in single-member districts leading to two-party competition. The first is a mechanical effect of the winner-take-all rule, which systematically limits the representation of smaller relative to larger, established parties. The second effect is psychological, as voters wish to avoid "wasting" their vote by casting it for a party with little chance of winning, behaviour known as strategic voting, modelled for individual voters by Alvarez and Nagler (2000) using survey data instead of vote shares alone. Cox (1997) extended this work as a problem of electoral coordination in which a district with M seats can sustain roughly $M+1$ viable competitors. Hence three-seat districts and 150-seat districts would put parties and their supporters in very different situations under a binary majoritarian/proportional framework (Clark & Golder, 2006). As a result, district magnitude has become a central measure of the degree of permissiveness of a country's electoral system (Taagepera & Shugart, 1989). Evidence from the radical right also fits this argument, as studies have found larger vote shares under more permissive rules (Carter, 2002; Golder, 2003).

The effects of institutions on voters and the effects of the same institutions on parties are confounded in overall vote shares (Becher et al., 2023). To tell these apart, we need to investigate whether permissive rules change the way in which feelings about issues translate into populist choices. To this end, we have to look at the various features of competition that together form the overall electoral rules of a country. These include the electoral formula, district magnitude, and legal thresholds, amongst others. Since these features are often joined

together in various ways across countries, it is difficult to isolate the individual effects of each. For example, as Golder (2003) showed, the relationship between permissiveness and radical-right success can vary in light of unemployment and immigration. Thus, the effects of permissive rules will depend, in part, on the broader political environment.

Previous research has established a strong relationship between populist attitudes and support for populist parties across countries (Van Hauwaert & Van Kessel, 2018). Testing the individual-level argument is harder: it requires comparing how the same voters translate the same attitudes into choices under different electoral rules. However, the Swiss case provides an unusually useful setting for testing our hypothesis. Lachat and Selb (2010) show that compensatory voting in Swiss National Council elections increases with district magnitude. This does not establish that electoral rules also condition the translation of anti-elite attitudes into populist voting. That question has not been estimated directly at either level of aggregation.

If electoral rules matter for that translation, the statistical consequence would be an interaction. Under restrictive rules, the voters most interested in a populist party have the greatest incentive to desert it, thus the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting will be flat. Under more permissive rules the same voters have less of an incentive to desert a populist party, thus the relationship will be steeper. However, it is also possible that the translation of attitudes into votes is completely unaffected by the rules of the election and that support for populist parties varies depending on the circumstances. Ladner (2014) reduces this concern in Switzerland. He compares candidates from the same party who ran for the two chambers in the same election and finds no greater degree of moderation displayed by Council of States candidates than by their National Council counterparts. Thus, any party difference observed at the chamber level is unlikely to stem from differences between candidates of the same party. The party-side explanation is not tested here; instead, we focus on the voter side and treat given variation in party supply (as identified by Meguid, 2005; Van der Brug et al., 2005) as not being modelled by this study's cross-context variation.

Note that the framework used in this paper is not restricted to populist parties. It can apply to any voter with a strong preference for an electorally disadvantaged minor party, as they face the same incentive to defect under restrictive rules (cf. Cox, 1997).

2.3 Hypotheses

Our two designs test the same hypothesis from different angles. The cross-national study contains strong institutional variation, while the Swiss design compares two ballots cast by the same respondent on the same day. Still, H2 should not be interpreted as a pure effect of the electoral formula. Even in Switzerland, the two ballots differ in other respects, including how candidate-centred they are, how the ballot is structured, and which parties compete (Ladner, 2014). The two relationships estimated by the two designs should therefore be seen as associations.

H1. The association between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting is stronger in electoral systems with higher district magnitudes.

H2. Among the same Swiss voters, the association between anti-elite attitudes and voting for the Swiss People's Party (SVP) is stronger on the proportional National Council ballot than on the majoritarian Council of States ballot.

3. Data and Methods

3.1 Cross-national study

CSES Module 5 consists of 56 post-election surveys conducted between 2016 and 2021 (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). The dependent variable is a vote for a populist party in the lower-house election. The CSES records the parties chosen in the list ballot and the candidate ballot separately. Only using the list variable would exclude the one-magnitude cases (Australia, Canada, the United Kingdom, India, Ireland and the United States). The analysis therefore uses whichever ballot type is relevant. Nevertheless, the partisan choice can still be determined. The selected party's code is then matched with the expert populism rating for up to nine parties in each study. We consider a party a party to be populist if it receives a rating of 7 or higher on the 0 to 10 scale (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023).

We require a minimum of 300 usable respondents and five populist votes in each study. After listwise deletion, 42 studies across 33 countries and involving a total of 53,230 respondents are retained, listed in full in Appendix Table A1. The excluded studies either had an insufficient sample size or populist votes, or lacked information on parties' populism scores or district magnitude. Even though including a minimum of five votes may have had some statistical costs, it was necessary to be able to estimate relationships of interest. However, since systems with low district magnitude tend to have lower proportions of populist votes, this rule may disproportionately exclude cases from these systems and thus reduces the ability to find evidence in support of H1.

The attitude scale averages five items from the CSES anti-elite attitudes battery: whether compromising involves selling out one's principles, whether politicians care about ordinary people, whether politicians are trustworthy, whether politicians are the main problem, and whether politicians serve only the rich and powerful (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). Four items are reverse-coded for higher scores to indicate stronger anti-elite attitude. Those who respond to fewer than three of the items are excluded. The resulting scale is standardised within the cross-national sample in order that one unit corresponds to one standard deviation (SD) of anti-elite attitudes. The sixth item from the CSES, which asks whether people, not politicians, should decide policy, is not included (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023): in countries where referendums are binding (for example, in Switzerland), this item might reflect support for the existing institution more than resentment towards the elites. The pooled Cronbach's alpha is 0.723, and, across the studies, the alpha value varies from 0.452 to 0.862 with a median of 0.754.

Electoral permissiveness, the explanatory variable, is operationalized as the natural log of the median district magnitude for the respondents in each study. This log is employed because the strategic difference between a district of one seat and of three seats is larger than between a

district of 31 seats and of 33 seats (Taagepera & Shugart, 1989). The results thus speak to moderation that follows this particular functional form; they do not rule out a relationship shaped differently between magnitude and the attitude-vote link. The median is used because of the highly right-skewed distribution of the district magnitudes within countries. Note that a correction is needed for the two studies based on the United States, for which the district variable gives the number of Electoral College votes. These are therefore given a magnitude of one, as is the case for the single-member districts in House of Representatives elections.

The main model is a multilevel logit with random intercepts and random slopes for the anti-elite attitudes in each election study. It includes an interaction between attitudes and log district magnitude, which directly tests whether the attitude slope becomes steeper as districts grow. The random slope allows the relationship between attitudes and voting to vary between studies. The controls include age, gender, level of education, position on the left-right political spectrum, and satisfaction with democracy, with each of these factors being centred. The dataset also provides a variable that notes whether a populist party had held cabinet positions before the election. Since a populist party in government is an established governing party and can gain support for other reasons than anti-elite protest (as identified by Jungkunz et al., 2021), it is also included as a control for this model.

For the cross-level interaction, the key information is the number of independent contexts. The 42 studies cover 33 countries, nine of which have two studies each. Even though the model uses 42 groups of election studies, having multiple studies in the same country doesn't mean they are completely independent, since they share similar backgrounds in terms of institutions and party systems. Thus, while 53,230 respondents are observed, the amount of independent cross-national information available to estimate the interaction is limited by the 33 countries. Multilevel models are known to estimate cross-level interactions imprecisely when that number is small (Stegmüller, 2013; Bryan & Jenkins, 2016), thereby the precision reported for that interaction should be read with this in mind. Two robustness checks are included: one uses the district magnitude of the respondent's district, and the other moves the threshold to classify a party as populist to 6 and 8.

3.2 Swiss within-respondent study

Switzerland's 2019 study is part of the cross-national sample. The analysis only includes respondents who cast valid votes in both the lower-house (National Council) and upper-house (Council of States) elections. The six single-member-district cantons for the National Council election are excluded, since their lower-house contest is effectively majoritarian. Listwise deletion yields a sample of 2,499 citizens from 20 cantons. Each of these citizens are included in the analysis once for each of their ballots in the lower-house and upper-house contests. The dependent variable for the lower-house contest equals 1 if the citizen voted for the SVP, whose populist score of 8 makes it the only Swiss party in the dataset with a populist score of 7 or higher.

For the Council of States, respondents in most cantons can choose up to two candidates. We use the first candidate mentioned by the respondents, as this is the closest to a single party choice that is offered in the ballot for the National Council. Note, however, that both ballots in

Jura and Neuchâtel are labelled as proportional, since these two cantons are the only ones electing their upper house in a proportional manner. The controls are the same as in Study 1 and are centred within the Swiss sample. The anti-elite scale is also standardised in this sample.

The within-respondent design fixes all respondents' characteristics constant between ballots. However, the design does not isolate the effect of the electoral formula, as other institutional elements such as candidate-centredness, ballot structure, and the parties competing also vary (Ladner, 2014). The estimate therefore captures the difference between the two electoral arrangements as a whole.

The model has random intercepts for both respondents and cantons. The intercept for the respondent takes in all the characteristics that are fixed for a person over the two ballots, and it is therefore possible to identify the ballot coefficient from the differences within a person. The intercept for the canton accounts for local variations in the strength of SVP. Since the random-intercept model assumes a distribution of these person-specific effects, the analysis is also carried out using a conditional logit model, with stratification by respondent. This version eliminates all the characteristics that remain constant for a given person, without making any distributional assumptions about them.

The main limitation of the Swiss test is the number of respondents who actually change their choice. The ballot coefficient and its interaction with attitudes are identified by the 209 respondents, out of 2,499, whose SVP choice differs across ballots. Everyone else contributes the same choice twice. The nearly 5,000 vote observations therefore do not translate into a large effective sample for the interaction.

4. Results

4.1 Cross-national results

Anti-elite attitudes are a strong predictor of populist voting, with a coefficient of 0.553 (0.089). The main question is whether that relationship changes with district magnitude. The cross-level interaction is -0.052 (0.053), with a 95 percent interval from -0.156 to 0.052 (Table 1). Its sign runs against H1. The estimate does not provide evidence for the predicted moderation. With cross-national information coming from only 33 countries, an effect of this size would be difficult to distinguish from no effect even if it were present.

The p-value is less useful than the confidence interval here: the latter shows which amount of moderation remains plausible. In terms of predicted probabilities, increasing anti-elite attitudes by one SD raises the probability of a populist vote by 6.2 percentage points in a one-seat district, 5.8 points at five seats, 5.4 at 15 seats, and 5.0 at 40 seats. At the upper end of the confidence interval, the implied increase in the attitude coefficient when moving from a single-member district to a 40-seat district is about 0.19, equivalent to roughly 35 percent of the main attitude coefficient. At the lower end, the same change would reduce it by about 0.58, which offsets the main association. Very large positive moderation therefore looks implausible, but smaller effects are still compatible with the data. Again, the limiting factor is the number of institutional contexts.

One control also has a substantial coefficient: where a populist party held cabinet portfolios before the election, the probability of a populist vote is higher, with a coefficient of 0.940 (0.374). Populist parties in government are established governing parties, so their support need not come mainly from anti-elite protest. Leaving the indicator out would push that difference into the other covariates.

District magnitude has little association with the level of populist voting either, with a coefficient of 0.131 (0.126). The four lines in Figure 1 remain close across the attitude range. The random slope variance is 0.290. This model does not explain that variation with district magnitude. The contexts differ, but the institutional variable used here does not account for the differences in slope.

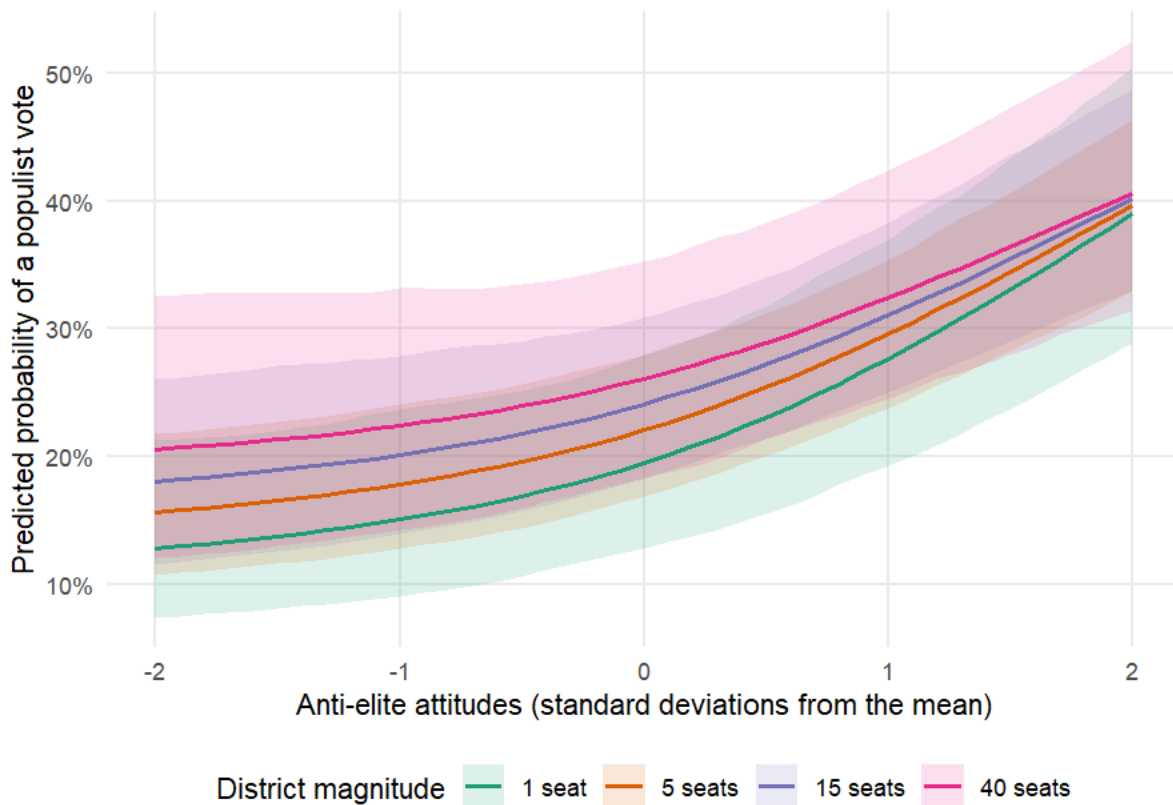
The result is similar in the robustness checks. When magnitude is measured at the respondent's own district rather than by the study median, the interaction is 0.013 (0.026), again indistinguishable from zero (Table 1, second column). Note, however, that this estimate is opposite in sign to the main specification, which cautions against reading either point estimate as a stable measure of the underlying moderation. Changing the populist classification threshold to 6 or 8 alters which parties count as populist and, because of the retention rule, which studies remain in the sample. The interaction is still -0.056 (0.051) at a threshold of 6 and -0.051 (0.054) at a threshold of 8 (Appendix Table A2).

Table 1. Populist voting across 42 election studies, multilevel logit.

	Study median magnitude	Respondent's own district
Anti-elite attitudes (z)	0.553*** (0.089)	0.528*** (0.088)
Log district magnitude (centred)	0.131 (0.126)	-0.065* (0.027)
Attitudes × log magnitude	-0.052 (0.053) [-0.156, 0.052] p = 0.330	0.013 (0.026) [-0.037, 0.064] p = 0.602
Age (decades, centred)	0.003 (0.007)	0.004 (0.007)
Woman	-0.108*** (0.022)	-0.109*** (0.022)
Education (centred)	-0.075*** (0.006)	-0.074*** (0.006)
Left-right self-placement (centred)	0.183*** (0.004)	0.184*** (0.004)
Satisfaction with democracy (centred)	0.006 (0.015)	0.008 (0.015)
Populist party in cabinet before election	0.940* (0.374)	1.055** (0.371)
Constant	-2.007*** (0.244)	-1.979*** (0.248)
Respondents	53,230	53,116
Election studies/countries	42 / 33	42 / 33
Variance: study intercept/attitude slope	1.642 / 0.290	1.702 / 0.300
AIC	48,855.0	48,700.4

*Note: Standard errors in parentheses; 95 percent interval and p-value given for the interaction. *** p < 0.001, ** p < 0.01, * p < 0.05, + p < 0.1. Both models include random intercepts and random slopes on the attitude scale by election study. The 42 studies come from 33 countries.*

Figure 1. Predicted probability of a populist vote by anti-elite attitudes and district magnitude.



Note: Population-averaged predictions from column one of Table 1, controls at sample means and random effects integrated out by parametric simulation. Bands are 95 percent intervals.

4.2 Swiss results

The Swiss comparison removes between-country differences, but it leaves the two ballots subject to the other differences described above. Anti-elite attitudes predict an SVP vote at 1.333 (0.221), while the proportional ballot has a positive coefficient of 0.688 (0.162). The interaction between attitudes and the proportional ballot is 0.182 (0.154), with a 95 percent interval from -0.119 to 0.483 (Table 2).

The curves in Figure 2 are close to parallel. Two SD above the Swiss mean, the predicted probability of an SVP vote is 22.9 percent on the proportional ballot and 17.7 percent on the majoritarian ballot. Two SD below the mean, the corresponding values are 3.2 and 2.8 percent. A one-SD increase in anti-elite attitudes leads to an increase of 4.9 percentage points on the proportional ballot and 3.6 points on the majoritarian ballot. The difference between the two ballots is therefore for the most part a difference in level, rather than in slope. Across the 2,499 respondents, 19.6 percent gave their National Council list vote to the SVP, whereas 16.9 percent of all voters named the SVP candidate first on the Council of States ballot.

The variance components provide an understanding of why the predictions in Figure 2 are at the level of population averages. The variance of the respondents' intercepts is 24.5 versus 2.2 for cantons. Therefore, on the logit scale, there is much greater variation among individuals than among cantons. These voter-level differences account for differences due to party identification, ideology, and other factors that remain constant across both ballots for each

person. A prediction based upon a respondent having an average level of random effects would tend to underestimate the average probability of voting in the population.

The result is similar without the random-intercept distributional assumption. A conditional logit stratified by respondent gives a ballot coefficient of 0.625 (0.156) and an attitude-by-ballot interaction of 0.084 (0.147). The interaction is smaller than in the multilevel model and remains far from conventional levels of statistical significance.

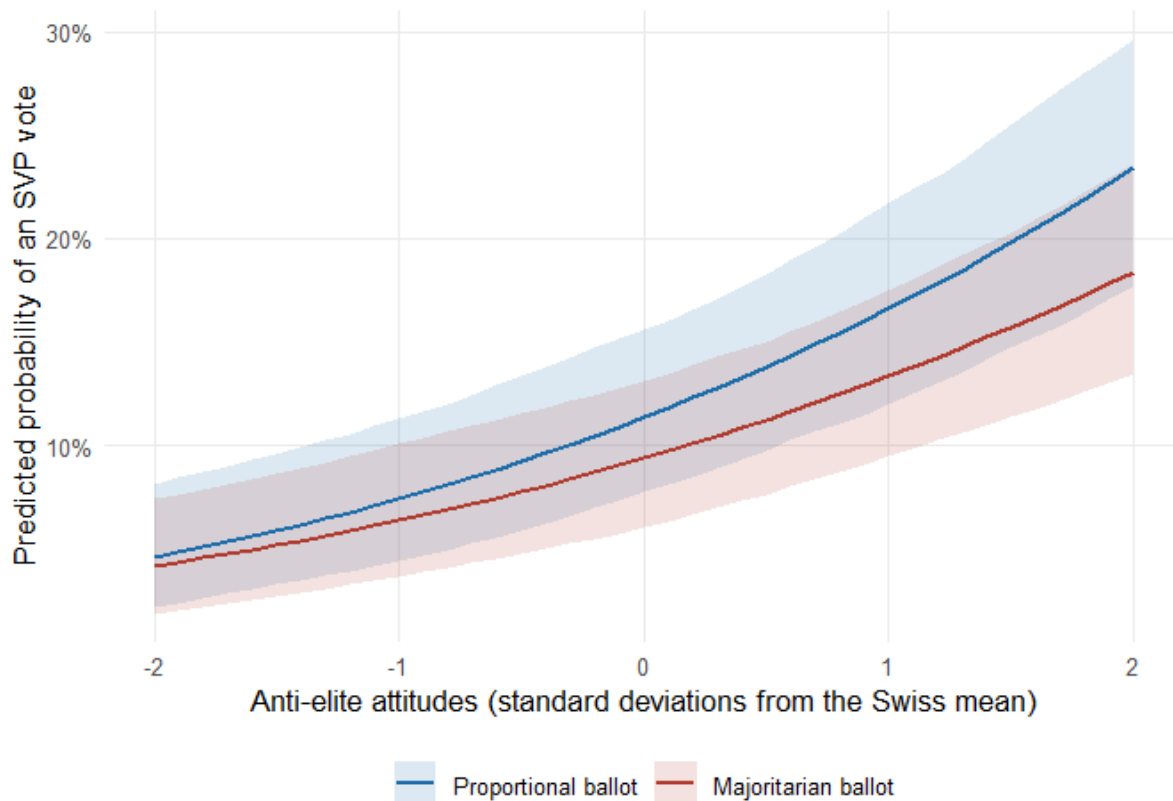
The estimated value does not exclude H2. This comparison was made possible by the 209 respondents whose SVP choice differs across the two ballots: 138 selected SVP for the National Council only, 71 for the Council of States only. A further 351 selected SVP on both ballots. The interaction is therefore estimated from a relatively small subset of discordant respondents, and its wide confidence interval reflects that. The absence of a significant interaction in this design is best read as inconclusive, not as evidence that no such interaction exists.

Table 2. SVP voting across the two Swiss ballots.

	Multilevel logit	Conditional logit
Anti-elite attitudes (z)	1.333*** (0.221)	dropped
Proportional ballot	0.688*** (0.162)	0.625*** (0.156)
Attitudes × proportional ballot	0.182 (0.154) [-0.119, 0.483] p = 0.236	0.084 (0.147) [-0.205, 0.373] p = 0.571
Age (decades, centred)	-0.118 (0.098)	dropped
Woman	-0.250 (0.345)	dropped
Education (centred)	-0.518*** (0.129)	dropped
Left-right self-placement (centred)	1.922*** (0.151)	dropped
Satisfaction with democracy (centred)	-1.466*** (0.326)	dropped
Constant	-7.713*** (0.705)	none
Vote observations / respondents	4,998 / 2,499	4,998 / 2,499
Respondents discordant on the SVP	209	209
Cantons	20	n/a
Variance: respondent / canton intercept	24.517 / 2.239	n/a
AIC	2,541.8	n/a

*Note: Standard errors in parentheses; 95 percent interval and p-value given for the interaction. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, + $p < 0.1$. Each respondent contributes two vote observations. The first column is a multilevel logit with random intercepts for respondent and canton; the second is a conditional logit stratified by respondent, in which everything constant within a person drops out of the likelihood. Both are identified by the 209 discordant respondents.*

Figure 2. Predicted probability of an SVP vote by anti-elite attitudes and ballot type.



Note: Population-averaged predictions from column one of Table 2, controls at sample means and random effects integrated out by parametric simulation. Bands are 95 percent intervals.

5. Discussion and Conclusion

While the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting is strong in both studies, there is no strong evidence that this relationship is even stronger under more permissive electoral rules. The cross-national interaction is close to zero and its confidence interval does not allow for strong positive moderation. The estimate is also robust to measuring district magnitude at the level of the respondent and to varying the threshold for classifying parties as populist. The Swiss interaction term is positive but imprecise and becomes smaller in the conditional logit. As it is based only 209 discordant respondents, the finding does not provide enough evidence to reject H2. Thus, the cross-national design provides evidence against a large positive moderation, while the Swiss design remains inconclusive.

Interpreting the results as evidence that district magnitude has no effect on populist voting would go beyond what the analysis can establish. Under the Swiss proportional ballot, the SVP performs better at any given level of anti-elite attitudes than it does under the majoritarian ballot system. But how much do voter-side coordination effects amplify the translation of anti-elite attitudes into populist votes at more permissive rules? Across all district magnitudes that we model, moderation larger than about one third of the main attitude effect is difficult to reconcile with the data, although smaller effects remain possible.

These results make a large voter-side coordination effect an unlikely explanation for why permissive rules favour populist parties, but they do not show that electoral institutions are

irrelevant to populist success. Hence, our results do not allow us to attribute the favouring of populist parties by permissive rules to the interaction of these rules with the populist options in the electoral supply. In order to test this alternative explanation, data on the entry and positioning of parties in different electoral contexts would be required, alongside the attitude data that was used in this design.

Several limitations narrow the conclusions. First, there are constraints related to measurement. The five CSES items measure anti-elite sentiment rather than populism in its conceptual entirety (Mudde, 2004; Schulz et al., 2018). This study examines the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and voting for parties identified by experts as populist; it does not evaluate populist attitudes themselves. There are also constraints related to cross-national comparability, as internal reliability ranges from 0.452 to 0.862 across studies, and measurement invariance is not evaluated, a check that cross-national tests of comparable populist attitude batteries suggest should not be assumed (Van Hauwaert et al., 2020). This is particularly relevant for H1: differences in attenuation across countries could influence the interaction even when the main attitude effect remains visible.

Second, there are constraints related to the number and characteristics of the cross-national contexts included in the analysis. The analysis includes 42 election studies from only 33 countries, meaning that the cross-national information does not come from 53,230 institutionally independent cases. Studies within the same country also share institutional and party-system contexts. This limits the amount of independent cross-national information available to estimate the interaction. Regardless of the number of additional respondents included within each country, this limitation would persist.

Third, district magnitude serves only as a proxy for electoral permissiveness. It does not provide information regarding electoral formulas, legal thresholds, or list structures. More generally, electoral institutions are not randomly assigned: reforms can themselves be influenced by political and party-system considerations, leading to a potential problem of endogeneity (Singer & Gershman, 2018). Consequently, H1 should not be interpreted as an estimation of a causal relationship between district magnitude and populist voting, but as a test of the moderation that is consistent with existing data.

Fourth, anti-elite attitudes are measured in post-election interviews in both studies (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). The respondents' answers may partly reflect the electoral outcome or serve as a post-event justification of the choice they made. The data therefore do not establish the causal ordering assumed by the theory.

Fifth, in the Swiss design, despite fixing every individual characteristic that does not change between the two ballots (which is its main strength), the interaction is identified by the 209 of the 2,499 respondents that change their SVP choice. The two ballots also differ in candidate-centredness, ballot structure, and the parties competing (Ladner, 2014). H2 therefore cannot be interpreted as the effect of a majoritarian formula alone.

Finally, the parties coded as populist are not a homogeneous group. The binary classification includes radical-right parties, left populists, and other anti-establishment movements (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). Their relationship with anti-elite sentiment

may differ. The results are similar when the classification threshold is changed, but that consistency cannot be interpreted as evidence that the mechanisms are the same across party types.

Overall, the evidence suggests that electoral permissiveness does not systematically alter the strength of the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting. It points towards electoral-supply and other contextual mechanisms as important explanations of cross-system differences in populist success (Meguid, 2005; Van der Brug et al., 2005).

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Appendix

Table A1. Election studies retained in the cross-national analysis.

Election study	N	Populist vote (%)	Median magnitude	Vote variable	Populist party in cabinet
AUS 2019	1,204	2.2	1	Candidate	No
AUT 2017	1,042	20.4	5	List	No
BELF 2019	871	20.0	20	List	No
BELW 2019	529	11.3	15	List	No
CHE 2019	2,772	23.7	9	List	Yes
CRI 2018	347	22.8	11	List	No
CZE 2017	785	43.3	13	List	Yes
CZE 2021	722	41.7	14	List	Yes
DEU 2017	1,493	10.1	1	List	No
DEU 2021	2,316	6.6	1	List	No
DNK 2019	1,025	20.3	16	List	No
FIN 2019	940	16.1	17	List	Yes
GBR 2017	722	1.5	1	Candidate	No
GBR 2019	1,550	1.2	1	Candidate	No
GRC 2015	655	44.6	8	List	Yes
GRC 2019	766	45.7	8	List	Yes
IND 2019	5,522	60.2	1	Candidate	Yes
IRL 2016	656	2.9	4	Candidate	No
ISL 2016	905	2.8	11	List	No
ISR 2020	776	36.3	120	List	Yes
ITA 2018	1,089	54.7	1	List	No
JPN 2017	955	5.2	1	List	No
KOR 2016	711	20.5	1	List	No
LTU 2016	635	6.1	1	List	Yes
LTU 2020	828	1.3	1	List	No
LVA 2018	489	34.6	25	List	No
MEX 2018	793	50.7	1	List	No
MNE 2016	445	16.2	81	List	No
NLD 2017	1,441	8.4	150	List	No
NLD 2021	2,284	33.0	150	List	Yes
NOR 2017	1,597	13.0	10	List	Yes
NZL 2017	1,267	52.5	1	List	Yes
NZL 2020	1,095	37.3	1	List	Yes
PER 2021	510	46.3	6	List	No
POL 2019	1,157	48.4	12	List	Yes
PRT 2019	617	22.4	19	List	No
ROU 2016	458	1.7	8	List	No
SVK 2020	580	49.1	150	List	Yes
SWE 2018	2,802	12.5	10	List	No

Election study	N	Populist vote (%)	Median magnitude	Vote variable	Populist party in cabinet
TUR 2018	719	56.3	12	List	Yes
USA 2016	2,169	50.8	1	Candidate	No
USA 2020	4,991	44.7	1	Candidate	No

Note: N and populist vote share are computed on the analytic sample after listwise deletion. Median magnitude is the median number of seats in the respondent's district. The vote variable column records whether the study supplied a list ballot or a candidate ballot.

Table A2. The two interaction estimates across specifications.

Specification	Interaction	95% interval	p	N
H1, main specification (study median magnitude)	-0.052 (0.053)	[-0.156, 0.052]	0.330	53,230
H1, respondent's own district magnitude	0.013 (0.026)	[-0.037, 0.064]	0.602	53,116
H1, populist threshold at 6	-0.056 (0.051)	[-0.157, 0.044]	0.269	57,412
H1, populist threshold at 8	-0.051 (0.054)	[-0.156, 0.054]	0.344	45,552
H2, main specification (multilevel logit)	0.182 (0.154)	[-0.119, 0.483]	0.236	4,998
H2, conditional logit stratified by respondent	0.084 (0.147)	[-0.205, 0.373]	0.571	4,998

Note: Each row is the interaction coefficient from a separate model, with standard error, 95 percent confidence interval, p-value and observations. H1 rows report the anti-elite $\times$ log-magnitude product. H2 rows report the anti-elite $\times$ proportional-ballot product. All coefficients are in log-odds.